



BEHIND RED BULL, FERRARI HAS STARTED THE SEASON WELL AND HAS EMERGED AS THE CLOSEST CHALLENGER TO THE REIGNING CHAMPIONS

at Ferrari, was aggressive in wheel-to-wheel combat to take a well-deserved third place. In Jeddah, the other Ferrari of Charles Leclerc completed the podium positions.

Sainz was forced to miss the race after participating in Thursday's practice sessions because of appendicitis. However, one of the best performances in Saudi Arabia was his replacement, Oliver Bearman, who made his F1 debut for Ferrari. The 18-year-old Briton got into the car on Friday morning for Free Practice-3 and qualified 11th before finishing seventh in the race, capping off an impressive performance on such short notice.

Firing on track, imploding off it

Even as the team is dominating things on track, Red Bull Racing finds itself in a hot mess following allegations of inappropriate behaviour by its team boss, Christian Horner, with a female employee. The news emerged before the team's car launch in February, and a subsequent independent enquiry by

the parent Red Bull company cleared Horner of wrongdoing before the first race.

However, during the Bahrain GP weekend, a trove of *WhatsApp* chats and other evidence was leaked to journalists and key F1 personnel. While the authenticity of it is yet to be ascertained, it has brought out in the open simmering tensions inside the team.

Jos Verstappen, Max's father, threw oil into the fire when he said Horner's continuation is untenable, fuelling speculations that Verstappen could leave the championship-winning team, especially now that there is a vacant seat at Mercedes following Hamilton's decision to join Ferrari in 2025.

Factory teams in trouble

Meanwhile, the two other factory-run teams, Mercedes and Alpine, have had a tough start to the season. Mercedes at least looked like it had turned around a corner during testing, setting some

No surprise: Max Verstappen kick-started his title defence in style, posting easy wins in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia in the first two weekends of the year ahead of his teammate Sergio Perez. GETTY IMAGES

headline-grabbing times. Still, the results from the first two races showed it is, at best, the third or even the fourth-fastest team on the grid. The team has struggled since the new regulations came into force in 2022, and the former champions have still not figured out the ideal operating windows for its cars.

At the other end of the spectrum, Alpine (part of the Renault Group) has had a torrid start to the campaign and is the slowest car on the grid.

Despite the full might of the Renault company behind it, it is an embarrassment for the team based in Enstone. The team has lost many key technical people, and the situation is akin to rats fleeing a sinking ship.